the Chinese a free hand, and resulted in the subsequent massacre of the convoy.

Avasthy in the meantime waited in vain at Sapper Camp for Nair to show up with Alpha and Bravo Companies. Finally, after destroying all essential stores that his men could not carry with them, he pulled out of Sapper Camp at 3 a.m. on the morning of 19 November to link up with Charlie Company waiting at Labrang. During the next two days, a few remaining survivors from 62 Brigade and others from Dirang Dzong (including Lieutenant Vinay Shankar) had swelled the ranks of his column considerably. With Dirang having capitulated without a fight and Bomdila having been lost to the Chinese, Avasthy decided his best option was to marshal the men under his command into the foothills via the Manda-la heights, through Phudung and Morshing.

In all likelihood, the Chinese were fully aware of Avasthy's column, which, by the time it crossed Phudung on 21 November, had swollen to almost 600 men. The Chinese had declared a unilateral ceasefire from midnight that day but that had made no difference to the troops on the ground as the killing spree continued unabated. The commander of 154 Regiment (419 Unit) had urged his men to ruthlessly gun down as many surviving Indians as possible. Two days previously, a sizeable Chinese force had crossed Rupa from the direction of Tenga and headed off towards Morshing in the hope of trapping the last remnants of 62 and 65 Brigades that might escape along that route.

In the early hours of 23 November, Avasthy's column reached Priyuding, a tiny hamlet at the mouth of the Morshing village bowl. While the main track led directly to Morshing along relatively flat ground, a track going to the right climbed up to the Lagyala Gompa before dropping down again sharply to rejoin the track at Morshing. At best, it was an additional loop that involved a steep climb to the last monastery that overlooked the old trade route.

At the bifurcation at Priyuding, an arrow indicated that the route to be taken should be via the Lagyala Gompa. There was a hurried discussion, with Avasthy thinking the arrow had been made by the villagers. It was decided that with his Charlie Company, Avasthy would take this route while the remaining two-thirds of the party would go on straight through Morshing. Should the Morshing party be ambushed by any Chinese troops, Avasthy could then cover their flanks. In any case, Avasthy told officers